

Generative AI Use Policy

ME 691 / CS 691 — Intelligent Optimization

Generative AI tools (such as ChatGPT, Copilot, Claude, etc.) may be used in this course within the boundaries described below. These boundaries are designed to ensure that AI supports your learning rather than replacing it. Misuse of AI in violation of this policy is considered academic misconduct.

Online Quizzes

AI tools may not be used in any form for online Blackboard quizzes. Quizzes are closed-book and closed-notes assessments meant to evaluate your individual understanding of each method. Using AI to look up or generate answers defeats their purpose.

Homeworks

AI may assist with specific, bounded coding tasks, subject to the following conditions:

What is allowed

- Using AI to help write small, self-contained code snippets or simple helper functions (e.g., evaluating an objective function, a plotting function).
- Asking AI to explain syntax errors, suggest fixes to a specific line of code, or clarify library usage.

What is not allowed

- Asking AI to implement the core optimization algorithm or any substantial portion of the assignment logic.
- Submitting code you cannot fully explain — if asked, you must be able to walk through every part of your submission.
- Using AI to generate, complete, or restructure your write-up or results analysis.

Written Work

AI may be used exclusively as a grammar and wording check on text or PowerPoint slides you have already written yourself. This mirrors the use of a spell-checker or a writing assistant.

What is allowed

- Pasting your own draft into an AI tool and asking it to correct grammar, punctuation, or awkward phrasing.
- Asking for suggestions to improve clarity of a sentence you wrote.

What is not allowed

- Asking AI to write, outline, or substantially rewrite any section of your report or presentation.
- Using AI to generate your analysis, interpretation of results, presentation, or critical review of a journal article.
- Submitting AI-generated text as your own, even with minor edits.

Studying

You may use AI tools to study course material (e.g., asking for explanations of simulated annealing, requesting practice problems, or clarifying concepts from the readings).

However, keep the following in mind:

- AI models can and do hallucinate — they may generate plausible-sounding but incorrect information, fabricated references, or subtly wrong algorithm descriptions.
- Always verify AI-generated explanations against the course textbook, assigned readings, or other authoritative sources before relying on them.
- Ask the AI to provide the sources it used, then look them up and verify the information directly before relying on it.
- Do not cite AI-generated content as a source in your submissions.

You will learn more by working through the material yourself. AI is a supplement, not a substitute. Even when using these models, understanding the content of this class and any others will not only help you detect errors but also improve your instructions and conversations with AI interfaces.

Final Remarks

Regardless of the section, if you use AI in any part of your work, please add a brief note at the end of your submission describing how you used it. This is not meant to penalize you — it simply helps us understand how AI is being used across the course.

Questions about whether a specific AI use is within policy? Ask the instructor or TA before submitting.